

PART II

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GRIEF AND A HEADHUNTER'S RAGE

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On the Cultural Force of Emotions

In what follows I discuss how to talk about the cultural force of emotions. *Emotional force* refers to the kinds of feelings one experiences on learning, for example, that the child just run over by a car is one's own and not a stranger's. One must consider, in other words, the subject's position within a field of social relations in order to grasp their emotional experience. This approach of showing the force of a simple statement taken literally instead of explicating culture through the gradual thickening of symbolic webs of meaning can widen our discipline's theoretical range. The vocabulary for symbolic analysis, in other words, can expand by adding the term *force* to more familiar concepts, such as *thick description*, *multivocality*, *polysemy*, *richness*, and *texture*.¹ The notion of force, among other things, opens to question the common assumption that the greatest human import always resides in the densest forest of symbols and that cultural depth always equals cultural elaboration. Do people always, in fact, describe most thickly what to them matters most?

If you ask an older Ilongot man of northern Luzon, Philippines, why he cuts off human heads, his answer is a one-liner, on which no anthropologist can really elaborate: he says that rage, born of grief, impels him to kill his fellow human beings. The act of severing and tossing away the victim's head enables him, he says, to vent and hopefully throw away the anger of his bereavement. The job of cultural analysis, then, is to make this man's statement plausible and comprehensible. Yet further questioning reveals that he has little more to say about the connections between bereavement, rage, and headhunting, connections that seem so powerful to him as to be self-evident beyond explication. Either you understand it or you don't. And, in fact, for the longest time I simply did not.

It was not until some fourteen years after first recording this

simple statement about grief and a headhunter's rage that I began to grasp its overwhelming force. For years I thought that more verbal elaboration (which was not forthcoming) or another analytical level (which remained elusive) could better explain the kinds of things these older men, when enraged by grief, can do to their fellow human beings. It was not until I was repositioned through lived experience that I became better able to grasp that Ilongot older men mean precisely what they say when they describe the anger in bereavement as the source of their desire to cut off human heads. This statement, taken at face value and granted its full weight, reveals much about how Ilongots can find headhunting so compelling.

The Rage in Ilongot Grief

The Ilongots number some 3,500. Living in an upland area some 150 km northeast of Manila, they subsist by hunting deer and wild pig and by cultivating rain-fed gardens (swiddens) and rice, sweet potatoes, manioc, and vegetables. Their kin relations are bilateral. Due to the fact that upon marriage the husband moves into his wife's home (uxorilocal postmarital residence), parents and their married daughters live in the same or adjacent households. Sibling ties among married couples in the senior generation link the dispersed houses within local clusters. The largest unit within the society, a largely territorial putative descent group called the *bērtan*, is manifest primarily in the context of headhunting feuds. Headhunting, for themselves, for their neighbors, and for their ethnographers, stands out as the Ilongots' most salient cultural practice.

When Ilongots told me, as they often did, how the rage in bereavement could impel men to headhunt, I brushed aside their one-line accounts as too simple, thin, opaque, implausible, stereotypic, or otherwise unsatisfying. Probably, I was naïvely equating grief with sadness. Certainly no personal experience allowed me to imagine the force of rage possible in bereavement for older Ilongot men. Such seemingly simple Ilongot statements thus led me to seek out another level of analysis that could provide deeper explanations for the older men's desire to headhunt.

In a representative foray along these lines, I pursued the deeper

explanation by trying to use exchange theory, perhaps because it had informed so many celebrated ethnographies, to solve the analytical problem. One day in 1974, I explained the anthropologist's model to an older Ilongot man named Insan. What did he think, I asked, of the idea that headhunting resulted from one death (the beheaded victim's) cancelling another (the next of kin). He looked puzzled, so I went on to say that the victim of a beheading was exchanged for one's own dead kin, thereby, so to speak, balancing the books. Insan reflected on this for a moment and then replied that he imagined somebody could think such a thing (a safe bet, since I just had) but that he and other Ilongots did not think any such thing. Nor was there any indirect evidence for my exchange theory in ritual, boast, song, or casual conversation.²

In retrospect, then, these efforts to impose exchange theory on one aspect of Ilongot behavior appear feeble. Suppose I had discovered what I sought? Although the notion of balancing the ledger does have a certain elegant coherence, one wonders why such bookish dogma could inspire any man to take another man's life at the risk of his own.

My life experience had as yet not provided the means to imagine the rage that can come with devastating loss. Nor could I therefore fully appreciate the acute problem of meaning that Ilongots faced in 1974. Shortly after Ferdinand Marcos declared martial law in 1972, rumors reached the Ilongot hills that firing squads had become the new punishment for headhunting. In past epochs when headhunting had become impossible, Ilongots had allowed their rage to dissipate in the course of everyday life as best they could. In 1974, they instead began to consider conversion to Evangelical Christianity as an alternative means of coping with their grief. Accepting the new religion, people said, implied abandoning their old ways, including headhunting. It also made coping with bereavement less agonizing because they could believe that the deceased had departed for a better world. No longer did they have to confront the awful finality of death.

The force of the dilemma faced by Ilongots at that time eluded me. Even when I correctly recorded their statements about grieving and the need to throw away their anger, I simply did not grasp the weight of their words. In 1974, for example, while Michelle Rosaldo

and I were living among the Ilongots, a six-month-old baby died, probably of pneumonia. That afternoon we visited the father and found him terribly stricken: “He was sobbing and staring through glazed and bloodshot eyes at the cotton blanket” covering his dead baby (R. Rosaldo 1980:286). The man suffered intensely, for this was the seventh child he had lost. Just a few years before, three of his children had died, one after the other, in a matter of days. At the time, the situation was murky as people present talked both about Evangelical Christianity and about their grudges against lowlanders as they expressed their anger and perhaps contemplated head-hunting forays into the surrounding valleys.

Through subsequent days and weeks, however, the man’s grief moved him in a way I had not anticipated. Shortly after the baby’s death the father converted to Evangelical Christianity. Altogether too quick on the inference, I immediately concluded that the man believed that the new religion could somehow prevent further deaths in his family. When I pursued this line of thought, an Ilongot friend sharply corrected me, saying that

I had missed the point: what the man in fact sought in the new religion was not the denial of our inevitable deaths, but a means of coping with his grief. With the advent of Martial Law, head-hunting was out of the question as a means of venting his wrath and thereby lessening his grief. Were he to remain in his Ilongot way of life, the pain of his sorrow would simply be too much to bear. (R. Rosaldo 1980:288)

Taken verbatim from my own monograph, this description now seems so apt that I wonder how I nonetheless could have failed to appreciate the weight and power of the man’s desire for “venting his wrath and thereby lessening his grief.”

Another anecdote makes all more remarkable this failure to imagine the rage possible in Ilongot bereavement. On this occasion Michelle Rosaldo and I were urged by Ilongot friends to play the tape of a headhunting celebration we had witnessed some five years earlier. No sooner had we turned on the tape recorder and heard the boast of a man who had died in the intervening years than did people abruptly tell us to shut off the machine. Michelle Rosaldo (1980:33) reported on the tense conversation that ensued:

As Insan braced himself to speak, the room again became almost uncannily electric. Backs straightened and my anger turned to nervousness and something more like fear as I saw that Insan's eyes were red. Tukbaw, Renato's Ilongot "brother," then broke into what was a brittle silence, saying he could make things clear. He told us that it hurt to listen to a headhunting celebration when people knew that there would never be another. As he put it: "The song pulls at us, drags our hearts, it makes us think of our dead uncle." And again: "It would be different if I had accepted God, but I still am an Ilongot at heart; and when I hear the song, my heart aches as it does when I must look upon unfinished bachelors whom I know that I will never lead to take a head." Then Wagat, Tukbaw's wife, said with her eyes that all my questions gave her pain, and told me: "Leave off now, isn't that enough? Even I, a woman, cannot stand the way it feels inside my heart."

From my present position it now is evident that the tape recording with the dead man's boast spontaneously revived among those listening powerful feelings of bereavement, particular rage, and the impulse to headhunt. At the time I could only be frightened and sense the force of the emotions experienced by Tukbaw, Insan, Wagat, and the others present.

The dilemma for Ilongots grew out of a set of cultural practices that, when blocked, were agonizing to live with. This blockage called for painful adjustments to other modes of experiencing their bereavement. One could compare this dilemma with Alfred Radcliffe-Brown's notion that ritual, particularly when not performed, can create anxiety. In this case, the Ilongot cultural notion that to throw away a human head is also to cast away the anger in one's grief creates a problem of meaning when headhunting is out of the question. What, then, is a man to do with the anger in his grief? Indeed, the classic Weberian problem of meaning is precisely of this kind. On a logical plane the doctrine of predestination seems flawless: God has chosen the elect but his decision can never be known by mortals. If a group's ultimate concern is salvation, however, this coherent doctrine proves impossible to live with for all but the religious virtuoso. The problem of meaning,

for Calvinists and Ilongots alike, involves practice, not theory. At stake for both groups are practical matters concerning how to live with one's beliefs, rather than logical puzzlement produced by an abstract doctrine.

How I Found the Rage in Grief

One burden of this essay concerns the claim that it took some fourteen years for me to grasp what Ilongots had told me about their grief, rage, and headhunting. During all those years I was not yet in a position to comprehend the force of anger possible in bereavement, and now I am. Introducing myself into this account requires a certain hesitation both because of the discipline's taboo and because of its increasingly frequent violation by essays laced with trendy amalgams of continental philosophy and autobiographical snippets. The vice of the latter trend, of course, is that reflexivity leads the self-absorbed Self to lose sight altogether of the Other. Despite this risk, as the ethnographer I must enter the discussion at this point to elucidate certain issues of method.

The key concept in what follows is that of the positioned (and repositioned) subject. In routine interpretive procedure, according to the methodology of hermeneutics, one can say that ethnographers reposition themselves as they go about understanding other cultures. One begins with a set of questions and subsequently revises them in the course of inquiry. Thus, ethnographers emerge from fieldwork with a different set of questions than those they posed on initial entry. Ask a question, in other words, and through surprise at the answer you'll revise your questions until lessening surprises or diminishing returns indicates a stopping point. This approach has been most influentially articulated within anthropology by Clifford Geertz (1974).

The view of interpretive method usually rests on the axiom that gifted ethnographers learn their trade through a broad course of preparation. In order to follow the meandering course of ethnographic inquiry, fieldworkers require wide-ranging theoretical capacities and finely tuned sensibilities. After all, one cannot predict beforehand what one will encounter in the field. Clyde Kluckhohn even went so far as to recommend a double initiation: first

the ordeal of psychoanalysis and then that of fieldwork. All too often, this view is extended so that certain prerequisites of actual field research appear to guarantee an authoritative ethnography. Eclectic book knowledge and a range of life experiences, edifying reading and self-awareness, supposedly vanquish the twin vices of ignorance and insensitivity.

Although the doctrine of preparation, knowledge, and sensibility contains much to admire, one should work to undermine the false comfort it can convey. At what point, for example, can people say that they have completed their learning or their life experience? The problem with taking too much to heart this mode of preparing the ethnographer is that it can lend a false air of security, an authoritative claim to certitude and finality that our analyses cannot have: All interpretations are provisional; they are made by positioned subjects who are prepared to know certain things and not others. Good ethnographers, knowledgeable and sensitive, fluent in the language, and able to move easily in an alien cultural world, still have their limits and their analyses always are incomplete. Thus, I began to fathom the force of what Ilongots had been telling me about their losses through the accident of my own devastating loss and not through any systematic preparation for field research.

My own understanding had been prepared a little over a decade earlier with my brother's death in 1970. By experiencing this agonizing ordeal with my mother and father, I gained a measure of insight into the trauma of a parent losing a child. This insight informed my account, partially described earlier, of an Ilongot man's reactions to the death of his seventh child. At the same time, my bereavement was so much less than that of my parents that I could not then imagine the overwhelming force of rage possible in such grief. My not having known the depth of rage possible in grief is rather general in the discipline. Ethnographic knowledge has the strengths and limitations given by the relative youth of most fieldworkers who, for example, have no personal knowledge of how devastating the loss of a long-term partner can be for the survivor.

In 1981 Michelle Rosaldo and I began field research among the Ifugaos of northern Luzon, Philippines. On October 11 of that year, Shelly was walking along a trail with two Ifugao companions when she lost her footing and fell to her death some 20 m down a sheer

precipice into the swollen river below. Immediately on finding her body I became enraged. How could she abandon me? How could she have been so stupid as to fall? I tried to cry. I sobbed, but rage blocked the tears. Earlier lived experience, on the fourth anniversary of my brother's death, had taught me to recognize heaving sobs without tears as a form of anger. This anger, in a number of forms, has swept over me on many occasions since Shelly's death, lasting hours and even days at a time. Such feelings can be aroused by rituals, but more often they emerge from unexpected reminders (not unlike the Ilongots' experience of their dead uncle's recorded voice).

Lest there be any misunderstanding, bereavement should not be reduced to anger, neither for myself nor for anyone else. Powerful visceral emotional states swept over me, at times separately and at other times together. Among other things, I felt in my chest the deep cutting pain of sorrow almost beyond endurance, the cadaverous cold of realizing the finality of death, the trembling beginning in my abdomen and spreading through my body as a form of wailing, the mournful keening that started without my willing, and frequent tearful sobbing. My present purpose of revising earlier understandings of Ilongot headhunting and not a general view of bereavement thus grants centrality to the anger rather than the other emotions in grief.

I should probably add that writings in English especially need to emphasize the emotion of anger. Although grief therapists routinely encourage awareness of the anger in bereavement, American culture in general ignores the rage that devastating losses can bring. Paradoxically, cultural wisdom denies the anger in grief even though members of the invisible community of the bereaved can be encouraged to talk obsessively about their anger. My brother's death in combination with Ilongot teachings about anger (for them, a publicly celebrated rather than a hidden emotion) allowed me immediately to recognize the experience of rage.

Writing in my journal some six weeks after Shelly's death, I noted: "If I ever return to anthropology by writing 'Grief and a Headhunter's Rage. . .'" It seems, as I discovered only a week before completing the initial draft of this essay, that I had made a vow to myself about how I would return, if I did so, to writing an-

thropology. Reflecting further on death, rage, and headhunting, my journal goes on to describe my “wish for the Ilongot solution; they are much more in touch with reality than Christians. So, I need a place to carry my anger—and can we say a solution of the imagination is better than theirs? And can we condemn them when we napalm villages? Is our rationale so much sounder than theirs?” All this was written in despair and rage.

This essay itself, in fact, has been cathartic, though perhaps not in the way one would imagine. Not until some fifteen months after Michelle’s death was I again able to begin writing anthropology. In the month before beginning this essay, I was ill with a fever and felt diffusely depressed. Then one day an almost literal fog lifted and words began to flow. Thus, the experience of catharsis enabled the writing to proceed, rather than the reverse.

By invoking personal experience as an analytical category one risks easy dismissal. Unsympathetic readers could reduce this essay to an act of mourning or to a report on a personal discovery of the anger possible in bereavement. Frankly, this essay is both and more. An act of mourning *and* a personal report, it simultaneously involves a number of distinguishable processes, no one of which cancels out the others. Indeed, in what follows I make precisely this argument about ritual in general and Ilongot headhunting in particular. The paramount claim made here, aside from revising the ethnographic record, concerns the way in which my own mourning and consequent reflection on Ilongot bereavement, rage, and headhunting raise methodological issues of general concern in anthropology.

Death in Anthropology

Symbolic anthropology in particular has privileged interpretations that ground their understanding in cultural elaboration and deeper levels of analysis. In practice, many analyses favor restricted spheres where formal and repetitive events take center stage. Consider, for example, Victor Turner on ritual process or Clifford Geertz on deep play in the Balinese cockfight. Studies of word play, in the same vein, are more likely to focus on jokes as programmed monologues than on the less-scripted, more free-wheeling impro-

vised interchanges of witty banter. Symbolic anthropology often focuses on rituals, ceremonies, games, and other activities played out in visibly bounded arenas. These events have definite locations in space, with centers and outer edges. Temporally, they also are well defined, with fixed beginnings, middles, and endings. Historically, they appear to repeat identical structures by seemingly doing things today as they were done yesterday. Their qualities of fixed definition liberate such events from the untidiness of everyday life so that they can be “read” like articles, books, or, as we now say, *texts*.

These remarks can take on more substance in the context of particular studies of death and its rituals. Take, for example, William Douglas’s book, *Death in Murelaga: Funeralary Ritual in a Spanish Basque Village* (1969). Notice that the title equates death and “funerary ritual.” The objective, Douglas (1969:209) says, is to use death and funerary ritual “as a heuristic device with which to approach the study of rural Basque society.” The author begins his analysis by saying that “death is not always fortuitous or unpredictable” (1969:19). He goes on to describe how an old woman, ailing with the infirmities of her age, welcomed her death. The description itself largely ignores the perspective of the most bereaved survivors and instead vacillates between those of the old woman and a detached observer.

Undeniably, certain people do live a full life and suffer so greatly in their decrepitude that they can embrace the relief death can bring. Yet the problem with making an ethnography’s major case study focus on “a very easy death” (I use Simone de Beauvoir’s title with irony, as she did) is not only its lack of representativeness but also that it makes death in general appear as routine for the survivors as this particular one apparently was for the deceased. Were the old woman’s sons and daughters untouched by her death? The case study shows less about how people cope with death than about how death can be made to appear routine, thereby fitting neatly into the author’s view of funerary ritual as a mechanical programmed unfolding of prescribed acts. “To the Basque,” says Douglas (1969:75), “ritual is order and order is ritual.”

Putting the accent on the routine aspects of ritual conveniently conceals the agony of such unexpected early deaths as parents

losing a grown child or a mother dying in childbirth. Concealed in such descriptions are the agonies of the survivors who muddle through shifting, powerful emotional states. Although Douglas acknowledges the distinction between the bereaved members of the deceased's domestic group and the more public ritualistic group, he writes his account primarily from the viewpoint of the latter. He masks the emotional forces of bereavement by reducing funerary ritual to orderly routine.

In a more recent compendium of the wisdom of the discipline, Richard Huntington and Peter Metcalf's *Celebration of Death: The Anthropology of Mortuary Ritual* (1979) takes another tack in dismissing the presence of emotions. They admit the presence of emotions but deny their extraordinary power for understanding ritual in lines of argument made classic by Emile Durkheim and Claude Lévi-Strauss. Their argument begins by using Radcliffe-Brown to assert that "crying at funerals is not merely tolerated, it is required by custom, and at predetermined moments the entire body of mourners will burst into loud and piercing cries. Just as suddenly, weeping halts and the tears that had been running so profusely cease" (Huntington and Metcalf 1979:24). They go on to applaud Radcliffe-Brown's notion that "the sentiment does not create the act, but wailing at the prescribed moment and in the prescribed manner creates within the wailer the proper sentiment" (1979:26). Thus far, the argument on emotions seems as standard as it is sensible, but note well that conventional wisdom defines ritual and obligatory behavior as one and the same. Collapsing the two eliminates the space for improvisation and spontaneous sentiment within ritual.³

When Huntington and Metcalf discuss Durkheim, they extend their argument on ritual weeping by saying, "We cannot assume that people actually feel the sorrow they express" (1979:31). Certainly, the obligatory acts of ritual do not arise from spontaneous sentiment, but neither should one assume that people do or do not "feel the sorrow they express." One could reasonably assume, along these lines, that certain people just go through the motions while other people's ritual wailing is heartfelt. Even here, however, one could not simply say that those most attached to the deceased most feel the emotions they express, whereas those most distant least

feel them. A death can touch one deeply because of its resonance with other personal losses, rather than because of one's intimate ties with the deceased. The point, in any case, is that analysis can assume neither that individuals do nor do not feel the sentiments they express during a funeral.

Huntington and Metcalf complete their dismissal of emotions in mortuary ritual by saying, "Though often intense, emotional reactions to death are too varied and shifting to provide the foundation for a theory of mortuary ritual" (1979:44). Thus far I am with them, but they go on:

The need to release aggression, or break ties with the deceased or complete any other putatively universal psychic process, does not serve to explain funerals. The shoe is on the other foot. Whatever mental adjustments the individual needs to make in the face of death he or she must accomplish as best he or she can, through such rituals as society provides. (1979:44)

Their claim that "in the face of death" individuals rely entirely on "such rituals as society provides" makes a crucial mistake: it collapses the ritual process and the process of mourning.

Surely, human beings mourn both in ritual settings and in the informal settings of everyday life. Consider, for example, the following passage from a paper by Godfrey Wilson that Huntington and Metcalf cite:

That some at least of those who attend a Nyakyusa burial are moved by grief it is easy to establish. I have heard people talking regretfully in ordinary conversation of a man's death; I have seen a man whose sister had just died walk over alone towards her grave and weep quietly by himself without any parade of grief; and I have heard of a man killing himself because of his grief for a dead son. (Wilson 1939:22-23)

Note that all the instances Wilson has witnessed happened outside the circumscribed sphere of ritual where people simply conversed among themselves, walked alone, or, more impulsively, committed suicide. The work of grieving, probably universally, occurs both within obligatory ritual acts and in more everyday settings where people find themselves alone or with close kin.

The general argument that Huntington and Metcalf make can easily be turned on its head. Just as the intense emotions of bereavement do not explain obligatory ritual acts, so obligatory ritual acts do not explain the intense emotions of bereavement. It is no more true that all intense emotional states are obligatory (as Huntington and Metcalf seem to claim) than to assert that all obligatory emotional states are intense. The approach to ritual advocated by these authors works to deny the socially consequential force of emotions that can overwhelm the bereaved, especially the chief mourners. Even in the face of volatile rage and sorrow, such analyses allow the comfort of denial through their focus on the elegant order often found in prescribed cultural elaboration.

Among the Nyakyusa, to return to Wilson's account, men danced with the passions of their bereavement. They described their feelings in this manner:

"This war dance (*ukukina*)," said an old man, "is mourning, we are mourning the dead man. We dance because there is war in our hearts. A passion of grief and fear exasperates us (*ilyyojo likutusila*). . . . *Elyyojo* means a passion or grief, anger or fear; *ukusila* means to annoy or exasperate beyond endurance. In explaining *ukusila* one man put it like this: "If a man continually insults me then he exasperates me (*ukusila*) so that I want to fight him." Death is a fearful and grievous event that exasperates those men nearly concerned and makes them want to fight. (1939:13)

Descriptions of the dance and subsequent quarrels, even killings, provide ample evidence of the emotional intensity involved. The articulate testimony by Wilson's informants makes it obvious that even the most intense sentiments can be studied by ethnographers (see M. Rosaldo 1980).

Whether resulting from notions of objectivity or dogmas about the indeterminacy of inner states, ethnographies that eliminate such qualities as anger, lust, and tenderness both distort their descriptions and remove potentially key variables from their explanations. My use of personal experience as a point of departure in characterizing the rage of grief for Ilongots has been, among other things, a vehicle for enabling readers to apprehend the force of emotions in another culture. Ilongot anger and my own, of course,

only overlap in a significant respect but they are not identical. Fantasies about life insurance agents who refused to recognize Shelly's death as job related did not, for example, lead me to kill them, cut off their heads, and celebrate afterward. Stating in such concrete terms the modest truism that any two human groups must have certain things in common can appear to fly in the face of a once-healthy methodological caution that warns against the reckless attribution of one's own categories and experiences to members of another culture. Such warnings against facile notions of universal human nature can be carried too far and harden into the equally pernicious doctrine that, my own group aside, everything human is alien to me.

Thus, in most anthropological studies of death, analysts simply eliminate emotions by assuming the position of the most detached observer. Their stance also equates the ritual with the obligatory, ignores the relation between ritual and everyday life, and conflates the ritual process with the process of mourning. The general rule, despite such exceptions as Wilson's account, seems to be that one should tidy things up as much as possible by wiping away the tears and ignoring the tantrums.

When analysts equate death with funerary ritual, they assume that rituals encode and store encapsulated wisdom as if it were a microcosm of the informal workings of everyday life in a culture. Johannes Fabian, for example, found during the decade of the 1960s the four major anthropological journals carried only nine papers on death, and most of those "dealt with only with the purely ceremonial aspects of death" (1973:178). The bias that so privileges ritual risks assuming the answers to the questions that most need to be asked. Do rituals, for example, always reveal cultural depth? Huntington and Metcalf simply reflect the received wisdom as they confidently begin their work by affirming that rituals embody "the collective wisdoms of many cultures" (1979:1). Surely this assertion requires investigation.

At the polar extremes, rituals could either display cultural depth or be brimming with platitudes. In the latter instance, rituals could, for example, act as catalysts that precipitate processes whose unfolding occurs over subsequent months or even years.

My own experience fits the platitudes and catalyst model better than the model of microcosmic deep culture. Even a careful analysis of the language and symbolic actions during the two funerals for which I have been a chief mourner could reveal precious little about the lived experience of bereavement.⁴ This statement, of course, should not lead anyone to derive universal knowledge from someone else's personal knowledge. Instead, it should encourage ethnographers to ask whether a ritual's wisdom is deep or conventional and whether its process is immediately transformative or but a single step in a lengthy series of ritual and everyday events.

In attempting to grasp the cultural force of rage and other powerful emotional states, one should look both to formal ritual and to the informal emotional states; one should look both to formal ritual and to the informal practices of everyday life. Symbolic analysis, in other words, can be extended from formal ritual to the inclusion of myriad cultural practices less elaborate and circumscribed. Such descriptions can seek out force as well as thickness.

Grief, Rage, and Ilongot Headhunting

Allow me now to sketch how considerations of cultural force apply to Ilongot headhunting. Perhaps we should begin by viewing headhunting as a ritual enactment of expiatory sacrifice. The raid begins with calling the spirit of the potential victim, moves through the ritual of farewell, and continues with seeking favorable omens along the trail. Most Ilongot men speak about hunger and deprivation as they take days to move slowly toward the place where they set up an ambush and await the first person who happens along. Once the raiders kill their victims, they toss away the head rather than keep it as a trophy. Before a raid, men describe their state of being by saying that the burdens of life have made them heavy and entangled, like a tree with vines clinging to it. After a successful raid, they say that they become light of step and ruddy in complexion. The collective energy of the celebration with its song, music, and dance is said to give the participants a sense of well-being. The ritual process involves cleansing and catharsis.

The view just outlined gains analytical power by regarding ritual

as a self-contained process. Without denying the insight in this approach, we must also consider its limitations. Suppose, for example, we view exorcism rituals as if they were complete in themselves and never consider them as parts of larger processes unfolding before and after the ritual period. What can we say about the state of being demented through possession? Through what processes does someone recover or continue to be afflicted when rituals fail? Failure to consider these questions can rob the force from the afflictions and therapies only partially actualized during the formal ritual. Still other questions could apply, not only to the person afflicted but also to such differently positioned subjects, as the healer and the audience. In all cases the problem involves the delineation of processes that occur before and after, as well as during, the ritual moment.

If the position just outlined critically can be called the *microcosmic* view, I should like to propose an alternative called *ritual as a busy intersection*. Rather than a self-contained sphere of deep cultural activity, ritual can be seen as a place where a number of distinct social processes intersect. The crossroads simply provide a space for distinct trajectories to traverse rather than containing them in complete encapsulated form. From this perspective, Ilongot headhunting can be seen as standing at the confluence of three analytically separable processes.

The first process concerns whether or not it is an opportune time to raid. In the past, historical conditions determined raiding patterns, ranging along a spectrum from frequent to likely to unlikely to impossible. These conditions, for example, have included American colonial efforts at pacification, the Great Depression, World War II, revolutionary movements in the surrounding lowlands, feuding among Ilongot groups, and the declaration of martial law in 1972. Ilongots themselves speak of such historical contingencies by analogy with hunting. Hunters say that one's opportunities lie beyond one's control, for who can say whether game will cross one's path or whether one's arrow will strike its target. My book on Ilongot headhunting explores these historical factors at some length (R. Rosaldo 1980).

Second, young men coming of age undergo a protracted period

of personal turmoil during which they desire nothing so much as to take a head. It is a time when they seek a life partner and contemplate the traumatic dislocation of leaving their families of origin and entering their new wife's household as a stranger. Young men weep, sing, and burst out in anger because of their intense, fierce desire to take a head and wear the coveted red hornbill earrings that adorn the men who have, as Ilongot say, arrived (*tabi*) before them. Volatile, envious, and passionate, at least according to their own cultural stereotype of the young unmarried man (*buintaw*), they constantly lust to take a head. During the initial period of Ilongot fieldwork, Shelly and I had abandoned our unmarried youths only the year before; hence our ready empathy with late-adolescent turbulence. Her book on Ilongot notions of self explores the passionate anger of young men in considerable depth (M. Rosaldo 1980).

Third, older men are rather differently positioned than their younger counterparts. Because they have already beheaded somebody, they can wear the red hornbill earrings so coveted by youths. Thus their desire to headhunt grows less from chronic adolescent turmoil than from more intermittent acute agonies of loss. After the death of somebody to whom they are closely attached, older men often vow to punish themselves until they participate in a successful headhunting raid. These deaths can cover a range of instances from literal death through natural causes or beheading to social death where, for example, a man's wife runs off with another man. All these cases share the rage born of devastating loss. This anger at abandonment is irreducible in that nothing at a deeper level explains it. Although symbolic analysis often argues against the dreaded last analysis, the linkage of grief, rage, and headhunting has reached rock bottom.

It is evident that my earlier understandings of Ilongot headhunting missed the full significance of how older men experience loss and rage. The position of older men proves critical in this context because they, and not the youths, set the processes of headhunting in motion. Their rage is intermittent, whereas that of youths is continuous. Thus, in the equation of headhunting, older men are the variable and younger men are the constant. Culturally speaking, older men are endowed with knowledge and stamina that their

juniors have not yet attained, hence they care for (*saysay*) and lead (*bukur*) the younger men when they raid.

In a preliminary survey of the literature on headhunting, I found that the lifting of mourning prohibitions frequently occurs after taking a head. Compared with reported notions, for example, that men cut off human heads in order to acquire either soul stuff or personal names (see McKinley 1976; Needham 1976; M. Rosaldo 1977), this account of youthful anger and older men's rage born of devastating loss lends greater human plausibility to the notion that headhunters can find their cultural practices compelling. Because the discipline correctly refuses to say that by nature headhunters are bloodthirsty, it must construct convincing explanations of how headhunters create an intense desire to cut off human heads. Hence, the significance in seeking an account of passions that animate human conduct by exploring the cultural force of the emotions.

Emotion, Ritual, and the Positioned Subject

Of the four major assertions made in this essay, the initial two concern problems that emerge from assuming a correct answer instead of raising a question that requires investigation; the latter two outline certain methodological consequences of speaking about the positioned subject.

1. Does cultural depth always equal cultural elaboration? Think of the speaker who is filibustering. The language used can sound elaborate as it heaps word upon word, but surely it is not deep. Depth, in other words, should be separated from the presence or absence of elaboration. By the same token, one-liners can be vacuous or pithy.

The concept of force calls attention to an enduring intensity in human conduct, which can occur with or without the dense elaboration conventionally associated with cultural depth. Although relatively without elaboration in speech, song, or ritual, the rage of older Ilongot men who have suffered devastating losses proves enormously consequential in that, foremost among other things, it leads them to behead their fellow

humans. Thus, the notion of force involves both affective intensity and significant consequences that unfold over a long period of time.

2. Do rituals always encapsulate deep cultural wisdom? Could they instead contain the wisdom of Polonius? Certain rituals, of course, both reflect and create ultimate values, key cultural conceptions, and the bases of group solidarity. In other cases, however, they bring people together and deliver a set of platitudes that enable them to go on with their lives rather than offer them insight.

Rituals can thus serve as the vehicles for processes that occur both before and after the period of their performance. Funeral rituals, for example, do not contain all the processes of mourning. It is a mistake to collapse the two because neither ritual nor mourning fully encapsulates or fully explains the other. In such cases the ritual process can be only a resting point along a number of longer processual trajectories; hence, the image of ritual as a crossroads where distinct life processes can intersect.

3. The ethnographer, as a positioned subject, can grasp certain ethnographic phenomena better than others. Most simply, the concept of position refers to a structural location from which one has a particular angle of vision. Consider, for example, how age, gender, being an outsider, and association with a neocolonial regime can influence what one learns.

Position can also refer to how one's lived experience both enables and inhibits particular kinds of insight. Nothing in my own experience, for example, had equipped me even to imagine the anger possible in bereavement. It was not until after Shelly's death in 1981 that I was in a position to grasp the force of what Ilongots had repeatedly told me about grief, rage, and headhunting.

4. Natives, as positioned subjects, also have their insights and blindness. This essay considers both the structural positions of older versus younger men and how lived experience positions chief mourners differently from those less involved. In reviewing anthropological writings on death, I often simply shifted the

analysis from the position of those least involved to that of the chief mourners.

From this perspective the positions of the ethnographer and the native should be considered in conjunction with one another. The following remarks by Pierre Bourdieu, despite his unforgivable use of the masculine pronoun, seem apposite here:

The anthropologist's particular relation to the object of his study contains the makings of a theoretical distortion inasmuch as his situation as an observer, excluded from the real play of social activities by the fact that he has no place (except by choice or by way of a game) in the system observed and has no need to make a place for himself there, inclines him to a hermeneutic representation of practices, leading him to reduce all social situations to communicative relations and, more precisely, to decoding operations. . . . And exaltation of the virtues of the distance secured by externality simply transmutes into an epistemological choice the anthropologist's objective situation, that of the "impartial spectator," as Husserl puts it, condemned to see all practice as spectacle. (Bourdieu 1977:1)

Similarly, most anthropologists write about death as if they were positioned as uninvolved spectators who have no lived experience that could provide knowledge about the cultural force of emotions.

Notes

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1. Force and related concepts, particularly those concerning emotions, have long been part of the anthropological vocabulary (see, e.g., H. Geertz 1959). In *Islam Observed* (1968), Clifford Geertz found it necessary to distinguish the force of cultural patterning from its scope as he delineated the contrasts between Moroccan and Javanese forms of mysticism. He states the distinction between force and scope in this manner: "By 'force' I mean the thoroughness with which such a pattern is internalized in the personalities of the individuals who adopt it, its centrality or marginality in their lives. . . . By 'scope,' on the other hand, I mean the range of social contexts within which religious considerations are regarded as having more or less direct relevance" (1968:111–12).

In his later works, Geertz develops the notion of scope more than that of force. My use of the term *force* differs from that of Geertz in stressing the concept of the positioned subject rather than processes of internalization within individual personalities.

2. Lest the hypothesis Insan rejected appears utterly implausible, I should mention that among the Berawan of Borneo "death has a chain reaction quality to it. There is a considerable anxiety that, unless something is done to break the chain, death will follow upon death. The logic of this is now plain: The unquiet soul kills, and so creates more unquiet souls" (Metcalf 1982:127). The Berawan, in other words, link a version of exchange theory to headhunting.

3. Like Douglas, Huntington and Metcalf conflate death and mortuary ritual by announcing the former in their title and specifying the latter in their subtitle.

4. Arguably, ritual works differently for those most affected versus those least affected by a particular death. Funerals may distance the former from overwhelming emotional states, whereas they may draw the latter closer to strongly felt sentiments (see Scheff 1979). Such matters can be investigated through the notion of the positioned subject.

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